

Crash Landing



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Convergence is the new gadget mantra, but not all converged devices make it past the labs—or flop when they do

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Convergence is, generally speaking, a good thing, and converged gadgets are supposed to make life easier for us. But not all converged products are good. Some, in fact, never made it to market. Others did and flopped.

It's not just about the products themselves being good or bad. It sometimes turns out that a good idea is not well-received by the market. It's a different story with each converged device that turns out to be an also-ran. No-one can pinpoint why some tack-ons, such as the phone-cum-PDA, become the norm, while others, such as the TV-VCR combo, never gain momentum.

Here, we take a look at some products that seemed to have been driven by market forces pointing towards convergence, but never became bestsellers.

Silicon Film Technologies' (e)film

Silicon Film Technologies' (e)film held the promise of changing regular film cameras into digital ones. This might have been a great product, because it would mean savings for people who already owned regular SLRs and didn't want to invest in a brand-new digital camera.

EFS-1, a 'digital film insert', was an electronic film cartridge that slipped into the back of an SLR camera

body. The (e)film cartridge could capture up to 24 1.3-megapixel images. You were supposed to be able to use your SLR the way you normally did—with the lens, filters and accessories. Your SLR camera could be loaded with (e)film, and any of its accessories could be changed without much trouble.

Since 24 images is generally considered insufficient, you could invest in an (e)box, where the images could be downloaded—after which you could continue shooting.

The product was expected to hit the market around 2001, but is yet to do so. What went wrong is not clear. But what's also at question is the utility of (e)film: would the captured images be as good as those captured by a digital SLR? And with costs of digital SLRs—as well as those of regular digital cameras—dropping, is there a place in the market for such an innovation?

This is, ultimately, an apparently good idea that didn't seem to have stood up to the scrutiny of the market.

The TV-VCR Combo

A TV-VCR combo is not be such a good idea, for multiple reasons. There are, in the market today, CRT TVs, LCDs, plasma displays, projection TVs, and more. VCRs—yes, don't forget the good old VCR!—also have multiple features such as super-fast motion, slow motion, freeze frame, on-screen programming and so on.